

in France in July 1938 on the refugee question, only 2 out of 32 countries present agreed to accept higher quotas of Jews. Britain restricted Jewish access to Palestine due to the growing civil war there between the Arab population and Jewish settlers. The last emigrants left Germany in 1941.

Ghettoization and murder

The German invasion first of western Poland in September 1939, and then of the USSR in June 1941, radically and tragically transformed Germany's anti-Semitic policies. With 3.1 million Jews in Poland and 2.7 million in the western



Ghetto roundup

Across Poland and occupied Russia, Jews were herded into walled or fenced ghettos in poor urban areas, where they had little or no food.

“... Europe will be **combed through** from west to east [of all Jews].”

MINUTES OF THE WANNSEE CONFERENCE, JANUARY 20, 1942

USSR, as well as more than a million in occupied France, the Low Countries, the Balkans, and Scandinavia, the Nazi authorities' reliance on emigration and small-scale attacks to “clear” Jews was no longer feasible. In Poland, the “*Einsatzgruppen*” (action groups made up from the SS—the elite core of the Nazi Party, whose leaders controlled the police and security) herded Jews into restricted areas of towns known as ghettos. Thousands more were sent to labor camps, where they worked for



Death train

Jews across Europe were rounded up and sent to the five main death camps in Poland. Many thought they were being sent to work in factories.



Mass murder

After death, Jews were stripped of everything, even their hair and the gold in their teeth. These shoes come from one day of gassing at Auschwitz.

the German war effort. As German troops swept into the USSR, the SS shot, or gassed in mobile vans, as many Jews as they could find. In Kiev, 33,771 Jews were marched out to the Babi Yar ravine and shot on September 29–30, 1941, one of many such incidents.

The “Final Solution”

Although a written order from Hitler has never been found, historians now date a decision on the “Final Solution of the Jewish Question” to late 1941. On January 20, 1942, Reinhard Heydrich, head of the Gestapo, summoned senior bureaucrats to a villa at Lake Wannsee in Berlin to ensure their support for his plans. Jews were now to be transported to camps in Eastern Europe, where they would be worked to death, or killed on the spot. Death was caused by mass gassing in sealed chambers, and the disposal of the bodies took place in huge crematoria staffed by Jews themselves. The death camps—Auschwitz, Belzec, Chelmno, Majdanek, Sobibór, and Treblinka—were supplied with trainloads of Jews from occupied and Axis Europe, except for Bulgaria, whose king refused to cooperate.

The killing was on a vast scale. Reports filtered out to the Allies, and the Auschwitz camp was photographed by a US reconnaissance plane in August 1944, but photo-interpreters were more concerned with a nearby chemical factory. Only when the Soviet Red Army advanced westward in 1944–45 did the camps cease work and the Holocaust end, with the total defeat of Nazi Germany in May 1945.

The Holocaust ended in 1945, but its legacy is still with us. Jews now have a homeland, but it is not without problems, and large-scale massacres of people solely due to their race or beliefs have continued to occur.

STATE OF ISRAEL

International revulsion at the Holocaust led the United Nations to create a Jewish state of Israel inside a partitioned Palestine in May 1948 414–15 >>. The Law of Return (1950) made Israel home not only for its inhabitants, but for all Jews, wherever they might live.

“ETHNIC CLEANSING”

Genocide did not begin or end with the Holocaust. Anti-Jewish pogroms broke out in Poland in 1947, resulting in the deaths of some Jews who had survived Auschwitz, while 2 million Cambodians were killed by their revolutionary government in the “killing fields” of Year Zero in 1975–79. More recently, 750,000 Tutsis were massacred by the majority Hutu tribe in Rwanda in 1994, while Serbs systematically killed thousands of Muslims in Bosnia in 1992–95 450–51 >>.



RWANDAN REFUGEES

YAD VASHEM

The Jewish national Holocaust memorial at Yad Vashem, Israel, remembers those who died, and focuses on the resistance of Jews to Nazi terror. Memorials now exist in many European cities, notably Berlin, and a National Holocaust Day is commemorated in many countries on January 27, the anniversary of the liberation of Auschwitz. Yet “Holocaust denial” has gained ground in recent years, as some historians and politicians have tried to rewrite, or even obliterate, historical events for their own ends.

